

THIS WEEK AT A GLANCE

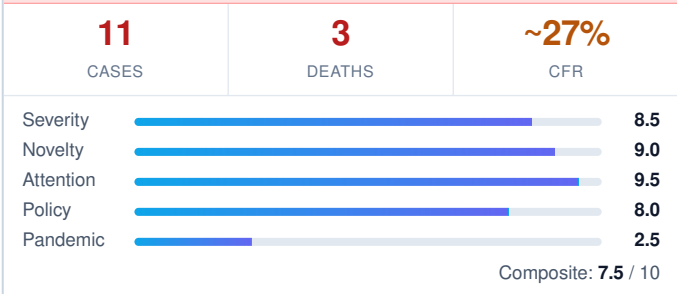
An acute novel transmission event dominates the briefing for week 20. Two longer-running concerns continue to require attention; one global threat has receded.

Bottom line: The Andes hantavirus cluster aboard the MV Hondius — 11 cases, 3 deaths, ~27% case-fatality, multi-country dispersal of contacts — is this week's leading signal because it is acute, novel in setting, and saturating both official channels and public attention. Mpox clade Ib remains a smoldering PHEIC with continued community transmission in five European countries. H5N1 stays on the long-watch list given persistent US dairy-cattle spread and a fresh fatal pediatric case abroad. Global public-health risk from the hantavirus event is currently assessed as low by WHO; pandemic potential is judged limited by independent virologists.

ACUTE EVENT · LEAD STORY LEAD

Andes hantavirus

Orthohantavirus andesense (ANDV) — MV Hondius cluster
Atlantic crossing · disembark Tenerife · contacts in 19 countries



WHY IT MATTERS

First known hantavirus outbreak on a cruise ship. Strong sequencing evidence of limited human-to-human transmission of Andes virus on board — the only hantavirus species with documented person-to-person spread. Passengers of 19 nationalities have now dispersed via military and government repatriation flights.

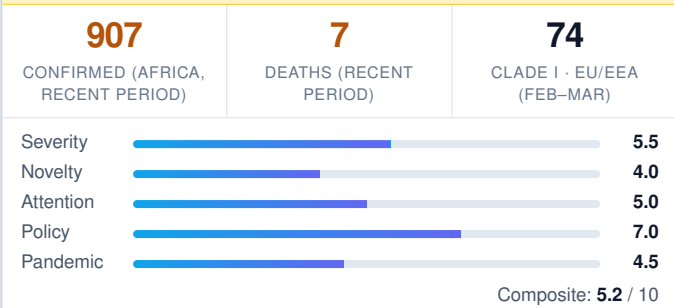
FOR POLICYMAKERS

- Coordinate cross-border contact tracing for repatriated passengers (incubation window up to ~6 weeks).
- Brief ports, cruise lines and travel-health authorities on rodent-exclusion and onboard isolation protocols.
- Avoid over-reaction: WHO assesses global public-health risk as low; no sustained transmission outside the ship.

SMOLDERING · PHEIC

Mpox (clade Ib)

Monkeypox virus, clade Ib
DRC, Madagascar, Uganda, Burundi, Kenya · community transmission in 5 European countries



WHY IT MATTERS

The overall African trend is declining since May 2025, but sustained community transmission of clade Ib continues in Austria, Belgium, Portugal, Spain and the UK, mostly in sexual networks of MSM. A WHO situation report (#65) and an ECDC weekly threats note both updated this month. A novel clade Ib/Ib recombinant has been flagged in WHO DON 2026-DON595 — worth monitoring.

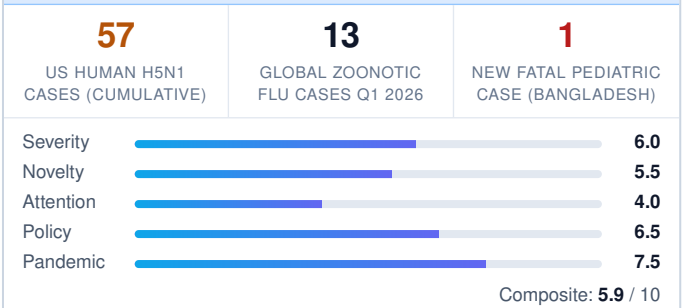
FOR POLICYMAKERS

- Sustain targeted JYNNEOS / MVA-BN vaccine availability for at-risk groups; supply tightening in some markets.
- Maintain non-stigmatizing messaging through community organizations; avoid travel restrictions.
- Fund continued genomic surveillance — clade I/II recombinants are emerging.

ON THE WATCH LIST

H5N1 / H5Nx avian influenza

Influenza A virus, H5 subtypes (incl. H5N1 2.3.4.4b, H5N5)
Cattle in 19 US states · sporadic human cases globally · 1st human H5N5 confirmed



WHY IT MATTERS

The headline number is quiet, but the substrate is not. H5N1 continues to spread in US dairy cattle across 19 states, with 57 cumulative human cases (mostly farm workers). May 2026 saw the first confirmed human H5N5 infection (NEJM) and one new fatal pediatric H5N1 case in Bangladesh. No sustained human-to-human transmission. Pandemic-preparedness risk remains the highest among the three pathogens here.

FOR POLICYMAKERS

- Maintain PPE distribution and seroprevalence studies for dairy / poultry workers.
- Accelerate H5 candidate vaccine procurement contracts (matched-strain stocks).
- Mandate bulk-tank milk surveillance; FDA retail-milk monitoring remains the early-warning workhorse.